

twelve

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Basie

Like all artists, jazz musicians play chiefly for the only public whose judgment they respect, that of other musicians. Like all artists, they run their art into trouble if they get too far beyond the control of the ordinary paying public which knows what it likes: provided it does not pay too much or know too much. If it pays too much, the temptation of tin pan alley may be too great: Mr. Bill Haley's rock and rollers *may* be competent jazz-players, but they can't show it in public. If it thinks it knows too much, it will get in the musicians' way. Far and away the best kind of public is one which does not much mind what the musicians play, so long as, speaking broadly, they make the right sort of noise and perhaps loose off a few fireworks now and then; a public which will incidentally allow players and arrangers to satisfy their own consciences.

Few places have provided better conditions of this sort than Kansas City in the years between 1920 and 1940, a hard bitten and remarkably "wide-open" town which has revolutionised the world of jazz, largely through the agency of Count Basie's band, which emerged from it in 1936, and arrived at the Festival Hall on Tuesday. Let us be thankful for Kansas City. Count Basie and his sixteen men are the finest jazz orchestra that has visited this country since Duke Ellington came here in 1933. Two of the British bandleaders who reported in force at the *première* were heard to say to one another in the interval, that they proposed to take their bands off Waterloo Bridge into the river. One sympathises with them, though the situation hardly calls for such extreme steps. Jazz as it is played by the Basie band is simply out of the reach of British musicians, and when they are again reconciled to the fact, they

can continue to entertain themselves and us in their more modest way, as before.

The band appeared in a decor which looked like a design for a sea-lions' pool, and was supposed to symbolise its music. Anyone who saw the players, greyish and relaxed with fatigue after their journey, face the press a few hours before going unrehearsed on the stand, will appreciate their mere achievement in getting through the evening. Heaven knows what these soft-spoken and far from simple men with poker-faced publicity smiles think, as the cameras take the photos which look exactly like those taken in a hundred other cities, or as they play *Low Life* admirably for yet another time. But they don't show it. A combination of extraordinary natural rhythm, supple, controlled and easy, and of equally extraordinary craftsmanship, makes this band not only a superb rhythmic and blowing machine—perhaps the best in the world today—but unforced and alive. This is probably due to the men's complete confidence in their own technical equipment and in one another. There is no doubt that this band comes to us as a team near the peak of its collective form. Some of it is also due to excellent arrangements written for this combination of players and for no other; though lack of rehearsal with the microphones exaggerated the brass somewhat. But the band does not depend on routines, for a group of them semi-improvised the traditional *Royal Garden Blues*, which is far from their normal repertoire, with almost contemptuous effortlessness.

Any way one likes to look at it, this is a very high-class band indeed. Its rhythm spreads with wonderful ease from the few deceptively simply chords with which Count Basie himself opens on the piano, to the rest of the rhythm section and thence to the brass and reeds until, as one admiring British musician said, "every man seems to be his own rhythm section." The soloists are superbly stylish, notably Joe Newman, a slim and elegant trumpet, Frank Foster, a boyish saxophone sporting the small goatee of the avant-garde coloured musician, and the trombone of Henry Coker. And the entire band refrains, with an almost insolent confidence in its powers, from the vulgar and simple tricks of the trade which set the teenagers rocking and rolling. It does not need them. At most it allows itself to batter at their emotions with a mass of brazen sound, but its best numbers are not its loudest, and the band knows it. Apart from a couple

of bravura pieces for the drummer and the bass player, Basie makes only one major concession to his singer, Joe Williams, an impassive tall man who hides his thoughts. Williams is a jazz-singer of considerable talent, who has greatly increased the band's popularity in America, but for one critic at least he cannot make Basie play the blues as James Rushing could in the distant days when he and the band first moved us with *Sent for You Yesterday*.

Anyone who wants to listen to a really first-rate coloured band at the peak of its present form ought to hear Basie. Until Duke Ellington returns to this country, British jazz-lovers will be lucky to hear anything which achieves or surpasses this standard of excellence.

Parisian Jazz

Artistically jazz, like *haute couture*, is a rather de-nationalised product. To the casual listener a 'New Orleans' band sounds much the same whether composed of Scotsmen or Japanese, a 'cool' quartet, whether composed of Singhalese or Swedes, which is natural enough since all are essentially imitating Americans. (The only local school of jazz which appears to behave with real stylistic autonomy is that of the *jive bands* in the Johannesburg slums.) Musically, therefore, the British jazz-lover who visits Paris crosses no frontiers. The 'traditional' jazz to be heard there is mostly worse than ours, the middle period and modern jazz rather better—thanks to the constant presence of expatriate American musicians of top rank—but otherwise there are few surprises. Mr Kenny Clarke, the drummer, holds together a variety of modern combinations at the *Club Saint Germain*, as he did in New York (including a startlingly good French pianist, Martial Solal). Michel Hausser, Henri Renaud and their partners at the *Chat Qi Pêche* sounds like the Modern Jazz Quartet, only not so good, because they are an imitation Modern Jazz Quartet. M. Guy Laffitte, as good a tenor-player as any in Europe, audibly echoes the Parisian expatriate Don Byas. As for the airy swinging trumpet of the veteran Bill Coleman and the blues-playing Mezz Mezzrow, who hold up the *Trois Maillets*, they belong to

Paris only because they live there; and owe most of their international reputation to the championship of French critics in the 1930s.

Socially, on the other hand, nothing could be more strikingly different from the jazz world of London than that of Paris. Though jazz has penetrated a long way into the zone of the certified and OK British intellectuals, the characteristic jazz fan here is still an adolescent electrician or apprentice tool-maker, a draughtsman or lab technician, a compositor, bank-clerk or junior technologist. If H. G. Wells were young today, he would almost certainly belong to some jazz club, and it is not without relevance that science fiction has been an extra-curricular interest of British jazzmen since before the war.

Not so in France, where jazz is almost exclusively an annexe of Left Bank intellectualism, and the sale of records dips sharply and regularly every June during the examination season, when the *lycéens* and students have other things to think about. There it has long been strictly OK. Jean Cocteau and Max Jacob patronised the review *Le Jazz Hot* in its early days, Sartre's. *Les Temps modernes* has long opened its columns to André Hodeir and Lucien Malson—needless to say, a *professeur de philosophie*—and at least one able professional bass-player began his musical life as a graduate sociologist. When a group of avant-gardists wish to make a documentary film about the *Palais Idéal* of the postman Cheval—a backyard Xanadu constructed by a Provençal Douanier Rousseau with Blakeian leanings, which has long been a hobby of the ex-surrealists—they naturally add a modern jazz sound-track. A very good one too, by André Hodeir. Except when they are tourists, the French jazz audiences look as though they have been rounded up from the terraces of the Quartier. Except when they are black Americans, French jazz players look like the intellectuals they are: that is to say either like the young Clemenceau or (allowing for glasses and the absence of the tonsure) like the young Abelard in a blue cardigan.

The Parisian jazz world has a few remote outliers on the right bank, survivals of its origins around Montmartre, but fundamentally it exists between the river and St Sulpice. virtually all the jazz worth listening to is to be found between the *Club Saint Germain* (neatly placed ten yards from both the *Flore* and *Deux Magots* cafés) and the *Troil Mailletz* in the Rue Galande, where the intellectuals border on the North Africans. If

Jazz were not played in cellars one might well go from one to the other within earshot of some drummer or other: via the *Tabou* (Rue Dauphine) where players go after hours, flanked by posters advertising German abstract art, the *Camelion* (Rue St André des Arts), and the Rue de la Huchette, which has come a long way since Elliott Paul's *A Narrow Street*, for it now contains both the headquarters of M. Ionesco's drama and the heaviest concentration of jazz clubs in the city, including the *Chat Qui Pêche* and Maxim's Saury's *Caveau de la Huchette*, the liveliest of the dying tribe of 'New Orleans' cellars. Explorers may tackle the *Cigale* (Bd Rochechouart), a street café where African musicians honk it out with more noise than finesse, visiting players drop in at the *Mars* (Rue Robert-Estienne) for news of what goes on, but at bottom it is all on the Left Bank.

It is a narrow, economically untenable world, which has ceased to expand: three years ago the French radio abandoned its annual amateur jazz contests. The provinces and the working classes have not yet come to its rescue, and in so far as they have turned to jazz, it is to the New Orleans music of Sidney Bechet, who gives 250 provincial concerts a year in a style despised by the Parisian avant-garde. The clubs charge excessive prices and are fast being replaced by *discothèque* joints without live musicians; the musicians, unless (American) stars, compete for casual work at 3–5,000 francs a night and may have to play for 1,500. No doubt the present depression—which local observers put down to politics, though it also affects Britain, which has no Algerian colonels—makes matters worse, but not much. Parisian jazz therefore retreats into marginal professionalism: occasional concerts, and film scores, which have lately multiplied, thanks to the commercial success of Vadim's film with John Lewis's score, and Louis Malle's *Ascenseur à l'échafaud* with Miles Davis. The most ambitious experimental jazz orchestra, André Hodeir's *Jazz Groupe de Paris* (2 trumpets, trombone, 3 saxes, vibes, bass, drums) has failed to establish itself commercially and remains a spare-time group whose members earn their living elsewhere.

In fact, like Parisian dressmaking, Parisian avant-garde jazz is a minority taste which must depend either on those who can pay a luxury price for it or on the export trade. But the French jazz public is not rich, even though its parents sometimes are, and the only real export market is

for the excellent books of French jazz critics and theorists: it is surprising how few French jazz records are released in this country. There remains the tourist trade, a natural sucker for cellar clip-joints, on which the jazz clubs can continue to rely, at least until the visitors begin to demand girls and floorshows. And yet: while French jazz maintains its intense intellectual liveliness and Paris its attraction for American musicians, somehow or other the horns will continue to blow in whatever is the most advanced style of the times.

The Duke

Whenever Duke Ellington is mentioned, the jazz critics dust off their superlatives. Since most of them have already been used up to celebrate his present visit, a few categorical statements will do for the purpose of briefing the squarer readers of the NEW STATESMAN. They may, therefore, take it that Ellington is certainly the most ducal figure in jazz—he has worn his title by right of elegance since the age of eight—and probably the most original composer in the U.S.A. His band is not only the finest but the oldest jazz orchestra, having functioned continuously since 1926—an awe-inspiring record for those who know the business—chiefly performing its leader's compositions. All these things are almost as surprising to the convinced Ellington admirers as to the outsider, for though there is no doubt about his achievements, they are as enigmatic as his public charm, or as the behaviour of his chief soloist, who looks and behaves like the most impassive of Orozco's Indians until he lifts his horn to produce the most lyrical invention in the history of the alto saxophone.

The stature of a mountaineer is judged not by the height of mountains he climbs but by their difficulty. Jazz critics admire Ellington so profoundly because they know the nature of the musical rock-faces he scales. He is more than merely Constant Lambert's *petit-maître*, a painter of musical pictures with a remarkable technical mastery in the precise mixing of orchestral sound and the interplay of solo and orchestra. He is the man who first recognised and solved the unbelievably difficult problem of turning a living, shifting and improvised folk-music into

composition without losing its spontaneity. Anyone can use jazz devices in orthodox composition or leave cadenzas blank for solo improvisation. Nobody but the Duke (in a peculiarly anarchically controlled symbiosis with his musicians) has produced music which is *both* created by the players *and* fully shaped by the composer. He has been so unique and so far ahead of his time that even jazz musicians sometimes fail to appreciate his originality, surprised to find some revolutionary device of modern jazz anticipated in the early 1930s, and that by a man who sees no reason to break with jazz tradition. For example, Ellington, alone in this as in so many other things, has consistently kept in his music two of the oldest sounds in jazz: the liquid New Orleans clarinet and the heart-rending vocalisations of the southern blues trumpet.

This remarkable man is now with us again for three weeks. A lifetime in the nightworld of show business, where blacks are acts and not men and only folding money is counted, has taught him to hide his intellectualism behind the mask of a courtly dresser and an expert on the women. It emerges in a certain bland ambiguity of his style (Ellington is a gift to students of ambiguity) and in his persistent musical wit. Perhaps it has also taught him to underrate his public, for at the Festival Hall he gave us the jazz equivalent of what a symphony orchestra would do if called to perform at a Butlin camp. But British jazz fans are probably more highbrow than the Ellington band, or perhaps more aware of a distinction which the Duke, who has an occasional fondness for cream-chocolate music, does not recognise. However, as the band has no prepared programme, it will no doubt adapt itself to the local demands. It is still unique and marvellous, though one of the Ellington musicians felt that, after a week's break, it was not yet quite played in again. This was, I think, a mistaken and unnecessary modesty. The Ellington musicians play, as the Moscow Art Theater acts, in a class of their own.

Blue Note

At a time when New York reports that 'religio-LPs enter big-time stakes' ('album interest has suddenly focused on the religious kick') we are apt to search nervously for grains of comfort in the stubbly fields of

jazz and pop music. We may find some in the fact that the current list of the ten best-selling jazz LPs/EPs in Britain contains two discs of authentic, uncompromising and uncompromised blues singers: the late Leroy Carr (*Treasures of North American Negro Music*, and the Terry-McGhee team, accompanied by Chris Barber. This advance of the blues is not unexpected. It is nevertheless a triumph for the small if influential band of fanatics which has for years systematically set out to infect an indifferent public with its own devotion to this difficult art; among them Humphrey Lyttelton, who has twice combined with Jimmy Rushing, and Chris Barber, who has pursued a fixed policy of importing blues and gospel singers for his band. So far as one can see Mr Barber gets nothing but spiritual satisfaction from these imports: it is the blues-singers who benefit by the chance to sing with what is (to the puzzlement of several critics) the most successful band in show business today. Few of those who came to hear the Barber band at the St Pancras Town Hall on Monday had ever heard, or even heard of, McKinlay Morganfield ('Muddy Waters') who also appeared on the bill. But it is a safe bet that henceforth this blues-singer, like his predecessors, will have a public of his own.

Muddy Waters, as his flamboyant trade-name suggests, practices a type of singing as yet unfamiliar over here. Rushing stands four-square on the floor, swaying his mighty bulk gently, and calling out his beautifully swung lines with ease, relaxation and equanimity preferably against a big band (*Little Jimmy Rushing and the Big Brass*, Philips LP). The late Big Bill Broonzy sang for the feeling of the words. Muddy Waters is a mannered, not to say a mannerist, singer who constructs patterns of voice and electric guitar, which make their emotional effect by systematically bombarding the audience with the loudest and bluest of blue sounds: a flamenco-sounding blues man. He is a large sleek-haired gypsy-like artist; at any rate he has the calculating air of the gypsy musician bending over the audience figuring how far and in what direction to let out the emotional stops. Not so his accompanist and half-brother, Mr Otis Spand, a chubby little player designed by nature to play the blues on a piano if ever a man was, and who ravishes us by nature as Muddy Waters does by artifice. An impressive team.

There is no getting away from the blues: the most sophisticated and modern players return to it. The fascinating Thelonious Monk drags a somewhat intimidated Gerry Mulligan into them on *Mulligan Meets Monk*. The late Art Tatum's *Trio Blues* can only be described as the *haute école* of piano blues, like Ulanova dancing Russian folk-dances: the whole of this sensational record belongs in every collection. There is no getting away from the blues: and a good thing too.

Count Three

The wise man who enters a formal jazz concert crosses himself, knocks on wood, or, if a rationalist, merely hopes against hope that this time it will come off. But generally it won't. There are very few jazz combinations which can be guaranteed to produce exactly what the public expects when buying its tickets; that is, if the public's expectations are high. One of them is once again among us, and this critic, a natural pessimist, took his seat in the Festival Hall with perfect, and justified, confidence. Count Basie's band did not let us down. What it does is musically modest, even by jazz standards. The 'Kansas City' formula for big band jazz, of which Basie is the master, and which is quite plainly the most workable yet discovered, is based on simplification and not complexity. (I am not struck by some of the cuter arrangements by Neal Hefti.) Out of the 'riff', the simple repeated blues phrase against which the soloist improvises, has come what André Hodeir calls the 'massive phrase', which is the foundation of all the Basie does. There may be higher things in jazz, but if it comes to ensemble swing, there is not, and perhaps never has been, anything like this band. Individually the soloists are often not of the first class. Indeed, they are generally well below Basie's classic early band. But as a team they have relentless rhythmic perfection. That band, even playing pianissimo, can lift people out of their seats like a crane.

To compare it with Ellington's, as superficial observers have done, is grotesque. Beyond the fact that both are 'big bands' by jazz standards—sixteen men in this case—they have nothing in common. Basie is no more like Ellington than Cobbett as a stylist is like James Joyce. Both

write prose well, but the one is trying to do a much more difficult thing with it than the other. Ellington is a subtle composer, Basie the leader of a group which has evolved a foolproof version of the big band blues. Ellington's band is a group of touchy prima donnas, Basie's a team of superlative craftsmen, with the collective pride of an élite regiment. (It must be the only band which itself fines players who turn up late). On its day the Ellington band is peerless, but its day is unpredictable. The Basie band, more modest in its ambitions, is utterly predictable, and consequently more consistently praised. What is equally to the point, Ellington is an individualist, Basie in the main stream of jazz. The most remarkable thing about his success is that it is achieved by playing straight unadulterated jazz, without gimmicks and acrobatics, a jazz independent of style in so far as it can absorb players of any style (e.g. the markedly modern Thad Jones and Joe Newman) with perfect ease. Even Joe Williams, with whom I was not much struck on the first visit two years ago, has developed into a first-class big-band ballad singer, though he is still not my ideal of a blues singer.

Travellin' All Alone

Billie Holiday died a few weeks ago. I have been unable until now to write about her, but since she will survive many who receive longer obituaries, a short delay in one small appreciation will not harm her or us. When she died we—the musicians, critics, all who were ever transfixed by the most heart-rending voice of the past generation—grieved bitterly. There was no reason to. Few people pursued self-destruction more wholeheartedly than she, and when the pursuit was at an end, at the age of forty-four, she had turned herself into a physical and artistic wreck. Some of us tried gallantly to pretend otherwise, taking comfort in the occasional moments when she still sounded like a ravaged echo of her greatness. Others had not even the heart to see and listen anymore. We preferred to stay home and, if old and lucky enough to own the incomparable records of her hey-day from 1937 to 1946, many of which are not even available on British LP, to recreate those coarse-textured, sinuous, sensual and unbearable sad noises which gave her a sure corner

of immortality. Her physical death called, if anything, for relief rather than sorrow. What sort of middle age would she have faced without the voice to earn money for her drinks and fixes, without the looks—and in her day she was hauntingly beautiful—to attract the men she needed, without business sense, without anything but the disinterested worship of ageing men who had heard and seen her in her glory?

And yet, irrational though it is, our grief expressed Billie Holiday's art, that of a woman for whom one must be sorry. The great blues-singers, to whom she may be justly compared, played their game from strength. Lionesses, though often wounded or at bay (did not Bessie Smith call herself 'a tiger, ready to jump'?), their tragic equivalents were Cleopatra and Phaedra; Billie's was an embittered Ophelia. She was the Puccini heroine among blues-singers, or rather among jazz-singers, for though she sang a cabaret version of the blues incomparably, her natural idiom was the pop song. Her unique achievement was to have twisted this into a genuine expression of the major passions by means of a total disregard of its sugary tunes, or indeed of any tune other than her own few delicately crying elongated notes, phrased like Bessie Smith or Louis Armstrong in sackcloth, sung in a thin, gritty, haunting voice whose natural mood was an unresigned and voluptuous welcome for the pains of love. Nobody has sung, or will sing, Bess's songs from *Porgy* as she did. It was this combination of bitterness and physical submission, as of someone lying still while watching his legs being amputated; which gives such a blood-curdling quality to her *Strange Fruit*, the anti-lynching poem which she turned into an unforgettable art song. (I need hardly say that this superb record, with its companion blues *Fine and Mellow*, is not available on British discs.) Suffering was her profession; but she did not accept it.

Little need be said about her horrifying life, which she described with emotional, though hardly with factual, truth in her autobiography *Lady Sings the Blues*. After an adolescence in which self-respect was measured by a girl's insistence on picking up the coins thrown to her by clients with her hands, she was plainly beyond help. She did not lack it, for she had the flair and scrupulous honesty of John Hammond to launch her, the best musicians of the Thirties to accompany her—notably Teddy Wilson, Frankie Newton and Lester Young—the boundless devotion of all serious

connoisseurs, and much public success. It was too late to arrest a career of systematic embittered self-immolation. To be born with both beauty and self-respect in the Negro ghetto of Baltimore in 1915 was too much of a handicap, even without rape at the age of ten and drug-addiction in her teens. But while she destroyed herself, she sang, unmelodious, profound and heartbreaking. It is impossible not to weep for her, or not to hate the world which made her what she was.

Status Seeking

Every day jazz is becoming culturally more respectable. To be precise, two quite different things are happening simultaneously. On the one hand, there are the usual attempts—more common, for obvious reasons, in the U.S.A. than elsewhere—to give jazz the accolade of accepted culture by putting it into symphonic programmes, summer schools, university courses and the like. On the other, there are the more numerous and significant attempts to make other cultural articles more attractive by borrowing jazz appeal; of which the Sunday TV programme known in the trade as ‘Jumping with Jesus’ is the most obvious. Messrs Christopher Logue and Charles Fox, whose jazz-and-poetry experiments still re-echo on record, frankly use jazz, among other things, to increase the sparse audience for poetry, though probably without success. But by far the most systematic attempt to draw jazz into the orbit of other arts has been made by the films. In the past two or three years the practice of commissioning film-scores from serious jazz musicians has become almost as fashionable as that of making socially conscious musicals. Several examples are before us now: Ellington’s sound-track—his first—for *Anatomy of a Murder*, Mandel-Mulligan’s for *I Want to Live*, and, of course, the French ones, of which the most recent and unsuccessful is Thelonious Monk’s sound track for Vadim and Vailland’s *Les Liaisons dangereuses*.

What has gone wrong with this at first sight exciting collaboration is simple and instructive. Roger Vadim is a technically bright director who, in spite of a good elementary feel for the moods of weather, sex and decadence, has always lacked any sensitiveness to the world around him.

He has merely observed that the people he makes films about listen to jazz in between, and sometimes while, making love, and therefore appear to regard jazz as little more than a suitably chosen background noise. So no doubt it is for them, but that is not enough for a film-score, especially not for one of *Les Liaisons dangereuses*, even for a version deprived of most of what made that book terrible and haunting in its original version, the transposition of revolutionary crisis into sexual terms. When Vadim commissioned the Modern Jazz Quartet to do the music for *Sait-on jamais*, John Lewis did the job of fitting the music to the sense and movement of the film for him. But, unlike John Lewis, Thelonious Monk, an eccentric and original composer, is also an almost purely self-contained one, who, one may guess, is not greatly interested in expressing or following moods other than his own, even if he were capable of understanding, or sympathizing with, what the characters in this film are after. In brief, all we observe is the pursuit of absolute logic by means of sex to the occasional accompaniment of music by Thelonious Monk. Good music: Monk is invariably worth listening to. But not a film-score.

Culture makes only a few tentative incursions into the massive programme of *Newport Festival Jazz* which opened at the Festival Hall last Saturday, and that mainly in the performance of Dave Brubeck, whose piano borrows heavily from classical techniques which are perhaps unfamiliar to jazz audiences but otherwise not striking. I am told that at a subsequent concert the Brubeck Quartet came to life. My own view, that its merits are modest, is not modified by a second hearing, though one cannot deny talent and devotion in Paul Desmond, who lectures mildly down his saxophone like an economics don evolving a theory of international trade. However, Joe Morello is a beautifully delicate and elegant drummer, if a very academic one. Brubeck was followed by Dizzy Gillespie in a Somali cap, light-grey suit, hornrimmed glasses and bent trumpet. Mr Gillespie (nobody who plays an instrument with such effortless technical command and musical intelligence should be patronised, even by reviewers) is as old-fashioned and vulgar a showman as Louis Armstrong: a mugger, scene-stealer, a music-hall comedian. He is at the same time an intellectual, and doubtless the only reason why he is no longer, as he once was, the acknowledged chief of

the *avant-garde*, is because the fashion there is for a more serious, introverted and humourless type of behaviour. He played everybody else in the programme under the table with contemptuous ease. I rather think that he is a great man.

The Buck Clayton All Stars, who are a seasoned band of campaigners from way back in the Thirties, had some difficulty in establishing themselves after Gillespie, but within a short time their straightforward professional swinging reconquered the audience. Buck Clayton himself, blowing lightly and strongly, a master-craftsman with feeling; Dickie Wells, still a wonderful trombonist; Emmett Berry, clear as only a jazz trumpet can be, and the rest, stood round on the stage like people at a cocktail party, moving casually into an old-fashioned front line to blow the audience out of their seats. The noble Jimmy Rushing after a poor start, finished strongly with the immortal blues *Goin' to Chicago* and *Sent for You Yesterday*. The old stuff is still irresistible.

Culture enters hardly at all into the music of Brownie McGhee and Sonny Terry, the blues-singers who are once again with us. Anyone who does not go to hear them is a fool.

Too Cool

For those of us who are Hindus, Jews or (like so many American jazz modernists) Muslim, the 1950s did not exist. By our own calendars we have a few more years to wait before generalising about the 'character' of the past decade. Still, as we are surrounded by men trying to sum up the past ten years, it is perhaps impolite to advertise our heterodoxy. Very well: what, from the jazz critic's point of view, has been happening since 1950?

Let me make no bones about it. Artistically the Fifties, though producing a far greater quantity of jazz in a far greater number of countries than in any previous decade, were disappointing. American jazz, which is still the only one that really counts, remained parasitic on the achievements of earlier years. The young modernists experimented aimlessly and eclectically, with the incidental results (familiar to students of modern painting and poetry) of making one 'cool' experimenter

indistinguishable from several dozen others; but the only innovations which retained their power were those of Parker, Gillespie, Monk, and the men of the Forties. The most important jazzplayer of the decade, and the one who best typifies it—Miles Davis—is an altogether lesser man than those who dominated earlier: an Armstrong or a Parker. He is a beautiful, melancholy, technically rather limited individualist, but no *chef d'école*, though the leader of an exceptionally fruitful small group. The most talented composer-leader of the period, John Lewis of the Modern Jazz Quartet, has confined his great gifts to the interior decoration of a few musical drawing-rooms. Compared to the vast mansions which were still being built and furnished by that old lion of the Twenties, Duke Ellington, and the ruthless *Bauhaus* explorations of that pioneer of the Forties, Thelonious Monk, Lewis's structures look pretty flimsy.

The Fifties did not even produce many new musicians of stature, a fact underlined by the long list of eminent obituaries during the decade: Bechet, Lester Young, Billie Holiday, Tatum, Catlett, Baby Dodds, among the older styles; Parker, Navarro, Clifford Brown among the moderns. Old talents were rediscovered or appreciated—Monk among the moderns, Buck Clayton, Vic Dickenson and several veterans of the Thirties—but there were few genuinely new faces.

Most of this sterility was due to a wholly disastrous desire to intellectualize jazz, to make it academically respectable, and at ease among the conservatoires, summer schools and biennales. Respectability is the death of a music which exists because it is a protest against artistic and social orthodoxy, and which operates in a way wholly different from 'straight' music. (Respectability does not even pay dividends: the man who, in the Fifties, became—with Paul Robeson and Kwame Nkrumah—the best-respected black in the world, was an old-fashioned jazz entertainer, Louis Armstrong.) Fortunately for jazz the musical failure of status-seeking became steadily more obvious. The jazz tradition, expelled by the front door, re-entered by the back. The reputation of the Fifties has been at least partly saved by what will, in retrospect, seem the most important phenomenon of their jazz history: the return to the blues.

Unlike the 'revival' movement of the Forties, which petered out in the Fifties (except among the young European public), this was no archeological reconstruction of the past. The blues which fertilised jazz,

including the most experimental and 'far out', was the contemporary urbanised black folk-music and gospel song which, thanks to the vast teenage commercial boom of the middle Fifties, enjoyed a fantastic popular vogue in the debased form of rock and roll. It is no accident that many of the 'hard blowers' among modern saxophonists play close to this style, that new musicians (like Coltrane and Ray Charles) have been drawn from the rhythm-and-blues field, and that connections with hot gospelling sects are today a valuable qualification for a jazz-player. Jazz is when men blow out their souls, and not merely musical figures. That is why Bix Beiderbecke is remembered, not because he 'used higher intervals of a chord as a melody line and backed them with appropriately related changes', thus anticipating Bird Parker. It is to the credit of the Fifties' jazz that, while not abandoning any of its technical sophistication, it began to rediscover this fact.

Miles Away

The most elusive of jazz musicians has once again escaped us. The trumpeter Miles Davis, who was recently to have opened a British tour, remains the only major living jazz artist whom we have not heard in the flesh, for reasons which are as vague and complex as all excuses for not turning up in show-business. Under normal circumstances this would be no reason for writing about him, but Davis is the sort of wraith-like artist whose characteristics are merely emphasised by his absence. What the devil is there to him? Something, clearly, or else he would not have topped numerous popularity and critics' polls in various countries—lately even in traditional Britain—ahead of Louis Armstrong or even the technically far superior Dizzy Gillespie. But what? The question is in its way as difficult to answer about him as about Lawrence of Arabia, and for analogous reasons. The 'image' of both men seems so much bigger than their measurable achievement.

Davis is a player of surprisingly narrow technical and emotional range; perhaps outside traditional blues-players the most limited artist to have achieved so high a reputation. Moreover, as has been pointed out, even within that range most of his records are not very good. A handful

of tracks in 1949–50 established him. A series of carefully spaced records since 1957 confirmed him; but even this latest, and by common consent most fruitful, phase of his art contains some notable failures such as his leaden and dragging *Porgy and Bess*. (On the other hand, on much of *Milestones* and some of *Kind of Blue*, it contains genuinely imperishable stuff.) And yet, what even the worst of his mature records radiate, and what almost certainly explains Miles's remarkable success, is an absolutely unmistakable sound and mood. The sound, at its most characteristic, is a very slow, ghostly, muted, faraway lyricism rather like what we might have expected if Tennyson had blown a jazz solo instead of writing 'Tithonus.' The mood, as one might expect, is one of total introversion and ranges from a reflective melancholy to naked desolation; but these sound as though felt by someone who, though not suffering from nightmares, is never quite awake. It is a sleepwalker's art, a lonely sound which plays before, after and beside, but rarely *with* other players. It is quite unforgettable. Film-critics have an almost infinite capacity for not noticing sound-tracks, but when Miles Davis did the accompaniment to a recent French thriller (recorded as *Lift to the Scaffold*, as usual on Fontana), Miss C. A. Lejeune did notice it. She said there was too much brass. It is a genuine if unorthodox tribute to Miles's power to project himself, all the more so as there is only one trumpet on the film-track and as Miles rarely raises it above his customary remote echo-sound.

What else is there besides this strange personality whose power lies in Davis's uncompromising hostility to the outer world? A genuine talent for improvising long, simple, often hauntingly beautiful arias, sometimes against backgrounds scored by Gil Evans. A gift, unexpected in so essentially uncooperative an artist, for inspiring the musicians who play with him in the small groups which are his natural habitat. The rare ability to suggest vistas beyond the sound of his horn, stretching into some sad sort of infinity. I do not think that he is a great artist, because as yet he lacks both the tragic and the comic dimension. But there are few more genuine poets in jazz, and no player who would make better background music for an exhibition of romantic art. The present vogue for him is justified; but I should feel happier if the young men and women for whom jazz is the only adequate expression of their view of

life, chose for their symbol a player whose art was less close to self-pity and the denial of life.

Manhattan Solo

When good Americans die they go to Paris, but when good jazz-fans die they unquestionably go to New York; it is to be hoped with a lot of celestial folding-money in their pocket, for this city is no bargain. On any given evening, somewhere between the Battery and the Harlem River, about three quarters of all living jazz musicians whose names are known to the foreigner can be heard or seen. Like everything else in this astonishing stone battleship of a city—the twin peaks of the midtown and downtown skyscrapers are its turrets—the concentration of jazz is awe-inspiring. And yet like so much else in New York, it has little organic connection with the city. Jazz is just there, a minority among the other minorities whose sum-total makes up the town, though the increasing conversion of Manhattan into a black and Puerto Rican borough will make it sound louder as time goes on.

To be precise, New York jazz is at least two minorities; and it is disturbing that they have so little relation with each other. Uptown there is the jazz of Harlem (the one that does not even get advertised in *The New Yorker*, otherwise a faithful guide to the music). This is the sort of noise you hear coming out of the dark belly of the *L Bar* on Broadway and West 148th, the visceral sound of Marlowe Morris's rhythmic organ-playing, rather like crystallised glue, or in the *Top Club* on West 145th, which is a simple minded place where men to go drink, girls to hustle and bartenders to give short measure. A little band, led by a former dancer, operates on the stand between the bar and the tables with two poorish sax players, a splendid swinging trombone called Buster Cooper and a handsome sweating shaven-headed entertainer, Titus Turner, who sings ballads, shuffles, but above all shouts some very gratifying fast city blues with comedy effects. It is not very ambitious music, but by God the place jumps and the clients at the bar laugh and stomp their feet as men ought to do when they are enjoying themselves. Those who listen to this music are not 'fans'; they are just people who like to have some entertainment

while they drink. Those who play it are craftsmen and showmen, who accept the facts of life in the jungle with disconcerting calm. 'The best drummers', says an eminent trumpeter over a drink, 'are either working or in jail'. Maybe they are, but this is the kind of statement which visiting Englishmen have to take time to digest.

A few miles downtown is the other kind of jazz, the *avant-garde*. Let me make no bones about it. This is by far the most impressive jazz played in New York today. Much of it is no doubt disappointing. John Coltrane at the *Jazz Gallery* is, like so many sax players, in urgent need of sub-editing. Dizzy Gillespie, at the same place, makes his concessions to the higher culture by not actually clowning, but he still refrains from using those incomparable gifts which make him potentially the greatest jazz musician alive. But Ornette Coleman at the *Five Spot* (in the confines of the Bowery) is a deeply impressive artist. The far-out boys do him an injustice by insisting on the revolutionary character of the sounds which, in defiance of all the rules of all musical games, he produces out of his plastic alto-sax, and which can only be described in words which carry unwanted overtones of depreciation: squeaking, neighing, honking and suchlike. Widening the technical range of an instrument is not enough to make a player more than a freak. The unforgettable thing about this very dark, soft-handed man playing with a vertical fold over his nose. Is the passion with which he blows. I have heard nothing like it in modern jazz since Parker. He can and does play the chorus of a standard straight—with an intense, voiced, lamenting feeling for the blues which lays this critic flat on his back. He swings. Beside him his trumpeter and pupil Don Cherry sounds a thin piper of experimental exercises. Coleman is a big thing in jazz, and it is to the credit of New York that it has recognised him in a few months, after years of lonely playing in the wilderness of the West.

But who has recognised him? The public at the *Five Spot* is overwhelmingly young, white, and intellectual or bohemian. Here are the jazz fans (white or black) with the 'Draft Stevenson' buttons, lost over their \$1.50 beer. If Coleman were to blow in *Small's Paradise* in Harlem, it would clear the place in five minutes. Musicians such as he are, it seems, as cut off now from the common listeners among their people as Webern is from the public at the Filey Butlin's. They depend on those

who are themselves alienated, the internal emigrants of America. And their tragic paradox is, that the value of what they blow lies not where they are going, but where they are coming from. The tragedy of modern jazz, as of most modern art, is that it moves further away from its roots.

Far Out West

Intellectuals are at present more strongly in favour of San Francisco than ever before. It is very beautiful and, as American cities go, untypical. Krushchev was welcomed here, the local students have organised demonstrations both against the un-American Committee and the American Legion (which has retaliated by reaffirming the guilt of Sacco and Vanzetti), and across the bay in Berkeley they have actually bred a strain of courteous cops. Instead of mobsters. San Francisco has a waterside union run by reds. Its beats, looking indistinguishable from their European equivalents, produce the largest amount of bad poetry for any square mile of the world, but still, poetry. By common consent, it is a good place to live in and a holiday from the rat-race; a place still haunted by the shades of the age before 'togetherness', by the giant robber barons of the Pacific, the over-lifesize labour heroes of the Thirties. Why, in defiance of all right-thinking sociology, at least one local radio station still angles its commercials frankly at 'the working-man'. (I need hardly say that it plays, not jazz, but 24 hours a day of hill-billy music.)

Whether another aspect of San Francisco, which affects the jazz-lover, rouses sympathy or not, depends on taste: it is 'a tight city'. There was a time when this place was as wide-open as any in the West. The citizens still take pride in recalling the occasion when Eisenhower, returning from Korea, gave a special salute to a particularly delirious group of female voters who happened to be the girls from the city's leading brothel. For there was action along the bay, plenty of action. This is so no longer. Mayor Christopher (a Greek—the cops and the graft are Irish) has shut the place down, and the far-seeing elements are already worrying whether the combined pressure of Reno and Las Vegas, which have every interest in seeing other towns moral, will keep the lid permanently half-

closed. But it is a well-known fact that jazz flourishes best in wide-open towns, for that is where there is most employment for musicians.

For a city which enjoys a world reputation as a jazz centre. San Francisco therefore possesses surprisingly few, and not very outstanding, resident musicians, and not much more than half-a-dozen jazz clubs, including the North Beach jazz-and-poetry type joints. What it does possess is a massive, enthusiastic and knowledgeable jazz public—mostly young, intellectual or bohemian—and therefore a power to make reputations which is much appreciated in the business. It made Brubeck and Cannonball Adderley. More recently (and characteristically) it has made chiefly the stars of the savage, jazz-impregnated social satire which flourishes, of all places, in night-clubs, Mort Sahl and Lennie Bruce. Sahl stands for wit, intellect, self-consciousness and hatred of the Right; Bruce who disappears behind his mimicries—for emotion, no self-criticism, horror and hatred of the squares. Sahl can, at a pinch, be understood by anyone who knows about America and psychoanalysis: Bruce is almost incomprehensible except to those who are steeped in the world of what Bernard Wolfe's Broadway novel called the 'late risers': the agents and acts, the musicians and junkies, the hustlers. But, like the other artists made by San Francisco, these too have followed the money east and are now only occasional visitors.

There is one exception to this exodus, San Francisco made the New Orleans revival in the early 1940s, but the musicians are still here, living off expense-account advertising men and the solid, but thinning, ranks of those who were young in 1940: a closed and passionate community. This public has provided a haven for meritorious oldtimers who have made their homes here: Kid Ory on the Embarcadero, Marty Marsala at the *Kewpie Doll* and the marvellously undimmed Earl Hines at the *Hangover*, though he has had to camouflage himself as a Basin Street type, which suits his piano-style about as well as the Petrushka music would suit a real fun-fair. But there is no limit to what a public with preconceived notions will impose on an artist. I have lately watched the legendary blues-shouter Sam 'Lightning' Hopkins performing to a packed, young, washed and wholesome house at the University of California Folk Music Festival. Hopkins, a lean, quietly wolfish character in very light slacks, white-and-black shoes, dark jacket, bow tie and dark glasses, was clearly

at a loss. They had given him a proper folky guitar instead of an electric one. They were selecting a repertoire for him, in tune with the folkniks. He hadn't quite settled down to the new act, which was shaping towards the elderly frail black preacher from the South, full of folky wisdom. He sang well, though not juiced up enough to be in really high gear, casually, in a voice both gravelly and soft, with a light, lifting guitar. Occasionally the voice bit like a pick. But he did not holler. That blue, rebellious and desperate shout from across the Texas tracks was no longer there.

For the rest, jazz in San Francisco is what happens in the beat joints (far-out, but not so good as London), what is on the two local all-jazz radio stations, and what comes on tour—chiefly the Ellington band, which followed the girls with the 44 inch bust in *Facks II* (business is business) until the place was closed down for non-payment of taxes. This was the jazz of our dreams, in the place where it belongs, melting a hard assembly of middle-aged lawyers, doctors, journalists and fixers like traditional brides. It reconciles me to much of the U.S., even to the memory of Louis Armstrong, on the eve of his sixtieth birthday, giving the Studebaker commercial over the air, 'tomming' as they say 'from the heart.'

The Old School

In America they would have had it the other way round, but in our tradition-minded country Jazz at the Philharmonic (Festival Hall) respects seniority. Cannonball Adderley's Quintet opened: an up-and-coming group led by a good saxophonist who has made modern jazz palatable to a mass public and is capable of more than he has yet given us. A collection of venerable and famous names closed the show. The most dazzling among them were Jo Jones, a bald extrovert drummer of vast and merited reputation, and unshakable rhythmic reliability, who ought to inspire several new clichés ('light as the touch of Jo Jones brushes'), and Benny Carter. Jazz critics feel about Carter as artists feel about some master of line like, say, Ingres: boundless, but vaguely cool, admiration. This is why he has rarely of late had his full critical due. He stood before us, watching the audience across his alto like a Latin maître

d'hotel his dining-room, and blew a single, firm perfectly judged line of sound at us the way a champion skater performs his figures. If Haydn's Prince Esterhazy had ever required a jazz player to liven up his musical entertainments, he might have done worse than choose someone like this cool, gentlemanly, extra-ordinarily original artist, who last stayed with us before the war, when *The New Statesman* did not yet report jazz concerts.

Coleman Hawkins, looking like an ambassador in a vodka advertisement who happens to be holding a tenor-sax, blew like a young man dissatisfied with all previous approaches to the instrument, even to some extent his own; and he practically invented it. This evening it didn't quite come off, but greatness must be saluted. Unlike him, Don Byas did not fight the natural lyricism of the tenor. Roy Eldridge, perhaps below his best, was on trumpet.

The most impressive performers of the evening, technically, were J. J. Johnson who plays the trombone as if it were a trumpet, and the unique Dizzy Gillespie (trumpet), the mystery man of jazz. Nothing is beyond this fantastically talented and intelligent musician, the first *chef d'école* of the modern jazz revolutionaries. Then why is it that his dead contemporary, Charlie Parker, is a legend, and his live co-revolutionary, Thelonious Monk, is once again an acknowledged musical innovator of stature, while Dizzy is merely the most dazzling trumpeter in the world? Why did Miles Davis, who is a beginner on his instrument compared to Gillespie, impress critics and public on his recent British tour as few other visitors have done, while Gillespie merely creates an impression of unsurpassable brilliance? Is it because this extremely reticent and devious artist hesitates to do the one thing which can raise a jazz musician to the very top, to reveal his soul? I do not know. But if ever he were to give us what is in him, a great many prevailing critical judgments would be sharply revised.

Mahalia

The age of Billy Graham and MRA is not the ideal one for a great religious artist. At any rate after Mahalia Jackson's third song two elderly ladies, who looked more familiar with church services than the rest of the

audience, walked out, leaving the Albert Hall to the sinners who can recognise the most majestic voice of faith they are likely to hear in our generation.

Mahalia Jackson, a huge, firm-fleshed woman whose face, radiating an internal beauty in repose, contorts with the love of the Lord when she sings, is one of those artists who are beyond good or bad taste. Musically and textually most gospel songs are sorry doggerel and distinctly inferior to the godless blues which Miss Jackson steadfastly refuses to sing. There are many musicians who would give her a more swinging accompaniment than Miss Mildred Falls, whose large light-blue figure sits by Miss Jackson's broad expanse of shining mauve. None of this matters, for Mahalia has the awe-inspiring gift of communicating the original and true meaning of words. When she sings the word 'soul', we know what it is. When she sings 'Oh Lord my God', sending out her leonine contralto like a gigantic whip, or 'You never walk alone', placing each syllable separately like a pillar of steel, we are with her in Zion. When she sings *I Found the Answer* ('Now the sun is shining for me each day'), we believe her.

Her answer is joy, a much rarer emotion than one might think, for it requires us not merely to accept life (which most of us eventually do) but to believe that it is or could be good. Mahalia's repertoire, which is very much her own, though as a solid show-woman she listens to advice about audience preferences, contains little at present about heaven and nothing about hell, but plenty about trust, certainty and exaltation. Even the traditional spirituals she sings at present, with the rocking drive of a big band, are those of confidence rather than longing; *Down by the Riverside*, *Joshua Fit the Battle of Jericho*, *Elijah*, *Jesus Met a Woman at the Well*, and especially that gospel cavalry charge, *Oh Didn't It Rain*. No doubt the joy of the gospel song is all the more massive because it contrasts with the uncertainty of real life. No doubt it is religious, because only in the spirit can the poor and mistreated be really free. As Mahalia sings (varying a familiar verse of English folksong): 'If religion was a thing that money could buy, the rich would live and the poor would die'. But it is joy nevertheless. It is unequivocally for life, a rare trumpet which gives a certain sound.

Her astonishing voice can produce anything from a small, round, convinced sound in the upper register to a deep, soft chest-tone of immediately communicated ecstasy and that unforgettable jubilant archangel call. As a good professional she knows her instrument, tending to finish each song with a characteristic effect—generally a deep-smear, rough-edged, bent sound placed somehow obliquely to the note it represents. As a good blues singer, she sings exclusively for the words, guided only by the basic pulse of the gospel beat. She is perhaps a shade less florid and more tranquil than in the past, with less of a tendency to build her solo as a series of increasingly hot choruses. But her native sense of swing is an unerring as ever, her power to announce the good news in the idiom of our century best designed for the communication of emotion as great as ever. We can congratulate ourselves on two things: that this very great woman and artist is universally appreciated as the queen of gospel singers, and that she has done us the honour of visiting this country.

Reluctant Monk

In France the hall would have been wrecked. As this was London, those who plainly regarded Mr Thelonious Monk as a clumsy bore merely walked out in a well-bred but marked manner. This was comprehensible, for Mr Monk, a sardonic and fey person at best, ostentatiously lost interest very soon, or else retired behind his private fortifications. Yet anyone who fails to hear him will miss one of the few original achievements in jazz.

Of the three or four real jazz composers Monk is the most primitive and limited, because nearest to the improvising soloist. Some great players, especially technically successful ones, soon discover what they can do and go on doing it, like Johnny Hodges, who plays today as he did in 1931. Luckily. Some, like Parker or the Beiderbecke of bop—Fats Navarro, suffer physically from their inability to leap over the chasm which separates the man who blows from the man who can also get others to express his ideas. Monk, perhaps because his piano technique is inadequate for his ideas, has had to leap that chasm. But what

preoccupies him as a composer is what fascinates the innovating soloist: experiments in timing—such as that extraordinary retarded, limping rhythm of his; instrumental adventures—he makes his bass play, at excessive length, like a blues guitar; but above all the ceaseless exploration of phrase and harmony. Fortunately his own compositions are mostly based on simple themes, which do not lose their shape even when taken to pieces in every conceivable way. He is not unaffected by current fashion, as witness his return to the oldest and most elemental figures of the piano blues. It is merely his curiosity, his search for new, even accidental, effects that never changes.

All this we knew and sometimes regretted, for the line between planned experiment and artistic abdication or incompetence is hazy, as in modern painting; and Monk has neither the technical mastery nor the staying power which enables an Ellington or John Lewis to maintain a steady level. Nor has he their orchestral sense. But what Monk's Quartet revealed at the Festival Hall in at least two pieces was a self-discipline, a taut classicism (greatly assisted by the admirable Lester Youngish tenor of Charlie Rouse) and a capacity not merely to indicate the directions of jazz advance, but to occupy, in a formally satisfying way, some of the new territory. And how many people are there today who can do this?

Not Art Blakey's Jazz Messengers who shared the bill with Monk. They are a first-class group with the strength and weakness of the 'blowing session': drive and virtuosity, on one hand, undisciplined trailing solos, rudimentary arrangements or clichés on the other. A properly arranged 'Dat There', one of the finest modern numbers I have heard in a long time, showed what they can do. Their chief asset is Art Blakey, a fantastic but somewhat obtrusive drummer who keeps an iron control over the rest, and a cadaverous young trumpeter of great promise, Lee Morgan.

Hello, Satan

Who writes the bony poetry of the blues? Nobody knows. A sung blues is a selection and combination of lines and phrases, polished and fitted together by a succession of singers into an aesthetic whole as

unplanned and coherent as an old-fashioned small-town square. To seek a single author is to miss the point. Except with Robert Johnson, the greatest of the Mississippi singers, and the only blues shouter whose voice is identifiably that of an individual poet. Virtually nothing is known of him except that he was born and raised on a plantation in Robinsville in the Delta, was probably killed by a woman at the age of 21 (or, as some claim, 30) and recorded 29 blues at two sessions in 1936–37 before disappearing from sight. Sixteen of them, including the fantastic ones from the second session, have now been reissued on a long-awaited disc in the Classic Jazz Masters series (BBL 7539) by Philips, the big company which reissues the most interesting jazz at present, and to which we also owe the marvellous John Hammond's *Spirituals to Swing* concert of 1938 (TFL 5187–8) and the Bessie Smith Blues of 1923–4. Johnson is not easily appreciated, for his Deep Southern accent is almost incomprehensible without repeated listening. One would willingly trade the anecdotal of the sleeve-notes for the only information which really matters—the text of his haunted songs.

The special and identifiable tone of Johnson's poetry is that of a man driven by fate and his own emotions. Both are personified in symbols and monsters standing by his side:

*I got to keep moving, I got to keep moving.
Blues falling down like hail, blues falling down like hail.
I can't keep no money, hellhound on my trail,
Hellhound on my trail, hellhound on my trail.*

His technique is not original. Visionary passion presses the usual worn images to a factual precision which gives them life. The blues is not merely personified ('Good morning blues, blues how do you do?'), it is a real figure—'Blues walking like a man'. The singer is not merely a man on the road, like any other:

*I got stones in my passway and my road seem dark at night,
Got stones in my passway and my road seem dark at night.
I have pains in my heart, they have taken my appetite.*

For Johnson is doomed. His day is spent in the company of the devil:

*Early this morning when you knocked upon my door—
I said ‘Hello Satan, I believe it’s time to go’.*

He knows he is not only unhappy but evil, as the mentally enslaved black believes himself not merely oppressed but rightly oppressed, for white is good and dark bad. Like that of the medieval vagabond artists, his tragedy is the Christian one of damnation. The cruelty of his god is the price he pays for his poetry, the brief and uncertain pleasure of women his only relief:

*I can tell the wind is running, leaves shaking on the tree, shaking
on the tree.
I can tell the wind is running, leaves shaking on the tree.
All I need’s my little sweet woman to keep me company.*

Johnson sings in a high African voice, neither fast nor dragging, accompanying himself with those frighteningly definitive blues sounds on the guitar. There is energy in his song but no hope. The world and the soul are his jail; and though he does not say so, his people’s. He has been dead these 25 years, but attention must still be paid to such a man. He has written his own epitaph:

*You may bury my body, ooh, down by the highway side.
So my old evil spirit can get a Greyhound bus and ride.*

God

Ray Charles comes to us with a greater preliminary flourish of typewriters than any previous jazz artist from the U.S.A. not excepting Louis Armstrong. He comes not as one but as three persons: a jazz and blues man, a pop star and a hipster saint, fourth in line to Lester Young, Billie Holiday and Charlie Parker. (All he still lacks is a holy nickname like Prez, Lady or Bird, though I understand in extremist circles a claim

is being staked for 'God'.) The combination is not only powerful but unique. Charles as a pop star is *big* by the standards of real size in that field, which are financial. He is said to make more than £300,000 a year, and even when we make allowances for publicity agents' attitudes to figures, he is a very rich artist, and quite certainly the biggest pop seller among those formed purely in the jazz mould, and the richest of those unhappy outsider figures whom the hipsters choose as their culture-heroes. It is the combination of the minority and majority elements in him which makes him so significant a phenomenon, though also one very difficult to judge lucidly.

Fortunately Charles's rise to the top has been so rapid that it is still possible to recall him clearly in his pre-mythical phase. I experienced him first in 1960, in Oakland, California, when he was already as big a draw as anyone in the black market—especially among the 'down home' immigrants from the South and South-West—but still totally unknown to all whites except a tiny handful of jazz and blues-lovers and some teenagers. His rapport with the black middle class was slight. I heard him at a function organised for this king of public, which approximately recalled the atmosphere at a Golders Green *bar mitzvah* party, and he went dead. On the other hand, in the same town, among the 4,000 at a rock-and-roll dance, who treated our contingent of a couple of dozen whites politely as unpersons, his performance was sensational.

The dance was in effect a secular revival meeting to celebrate sex instead of God, and even today his strongest numbers deliberately use the tried hot-gospel machine for whipping up divine ecstasy, to heat the bedrooms of our imagination. A pure gospel-number, shared between the call of Charles at the piano and the response of the four very undivine-looking Raelets, and apparently about the Lord, will end with the consciously shocking words: 'I'm talking about my baby'. Old-fashioned worldly blues-singers like Big Bill Broonzy disapproved of this tearing down of moral frontiers. 'He's a mess,' he said, with some justification. 'He's a-crying sanctified. He's mixing the blues with the spirituals. I *know* that's wrong. You shouldn't mix them. He's got a good voice, but it's a church voice.' At all events the congregation in Oakland reacted as though a prophet were present. There was not much dancing, merely a general, silent, massed slow heaving, broken by occasional cries of assent

and release. It was an extraordinary experience, deeply moving and disturbing.

The audience at the Finsbury Astoria was not like that—although, since Charles has never quite captured the *Jukebox Jury* public over here, it had some affinities with Oakland, being largely an audience of jazz-lovers rather than pop fans. The tension was lower, and Charles had also diluted his material with the pop-market numbers which have made him such a wide seller, such as ballads and a sort of lachrymose hipster hillbilly. It was possible to judge him dispassionately for about half the time. He is, let us make no mistake about it, a very great star. His alto-playing is undistinguished and his piano-playing far from outstanding. Nor is he technically a great blues-singer, though he is an entirely genuine one. But his voice has star quality to an astonishing degree. Since Charles is blind and therefore virtually immobile—except for a few tentative jerky steps and a shifting of his dark glasses—it must carry the entire burden of his communication with the audience. (The big band is, or was on this occasion, nowhere near as tight and electric as such a talented group should be, and the Raelets are mere adjuncts to Ray.) But the voice is remarkable, soft and furry or abrasive at will, at times high, clear and ecstatic, keeling over into the strangled frenzy of the top-gear preacher, or full of a hot desperation. It would not be right to say that he manages it with the light, contemptuous certainty of a champion, though his professionalism with a microphone is obvious. Ray Charles exists in that border world of the great performers in which the distinction between sincerity and insincerity, between deliberate effect and living emotion, has lost its meaning. What he does coolly, plays on his emotions as well as ours; what he does in passion, comes out as showmanship. The *monstre sacré* is a frightening spectacle. The hunched, thin, unhappy blind man who can sing ‘Careless Love’ (which is about something quite different), milking all the public’s emotion out of the repeated, dragged out, at once ambiguous and clear lines ‘Once I was blind, but now I can see’, can make even the insensitive shiver.

There is no mystery about why he has maintained the full loyalty of the jazzmen from among whom he has sprung. What he sings and plays is the blues, ancient and modern, and they can comfort themselves with the thought that he proves what they have always known, that what they

feel in jazz and the blues can capture the millions. There is no mystery about his popular appeal. Once the masses have become acclimatised to the idiom of the blues, as they have been, thanks to rock-and-roll, it is inconceivable that a man of Charles's gifts should not mow down like grass any audience with the slightest experience of adult emotions. And there is no mystery about his cult among the hipsters, for a blind orphan black, in trouble about narcotics and putting down authentic jazz, exactly fits their specifications. It must be said, however, that he is neither as original nor as great an artist as the other gods in the hipster pantheon. Unlike Billie Holiday and Parker, and in spite of the publicity, he is *not* a genius, and is intelligent enough to be the first to admit it.

What links the audience at the Finsbury Astoria with the Oakland immigrants and the American teenage record-buyers is not merely the quality of the voice. It is the idiom of the black big-city ghetto, which has become, through jazz and its influence on popular music, the idiom of our modern Western urban subcivilisations. It is the nature of the song: the cry of the victim, the defeated, the outcast, the lost and isolated individual for whom nothing of real value remains except private intensities of feeling. For them the senses have replaced the sense of life, and Ray Charles is what Marx said of religion, the heart of a heartless world—our own. One must salute talent when one sees it. Charles is a star. But one cannot escape the thought that a world in which he is a star is an unhappy and a sick world.

Duke

Duke Ellington has at last decided that the English are grown up, at any rate those numerous English who are prepared to cancel even their skiing holidays to listen to him. Slowly, because he is as used to morons as anyone else in the business of popular entertainment, of which he has formed part for 40 years, he has realised that London need not be fed violin solos of *Autumn Leaves*, or even pot-pourris of past Ellingtoniana. His present programme does contain one casually strung together medley and (luckily) a few of those simple, sophisticated and indestructible tunes which for many of us mean Ellington: 'Things Ain't What They Used to

Be' (superlatively carried by Johnny Hodges), 'Caravan', 'Stomp Jones'. But most of his programme was new, unfamiliar and, which shows an even greater confidence in the audience, high-brow. The band plays four pieces from a new and as yet uncompleted *Far Eastern Suite*, the product of last year's government-sponsored tour to Asia, two pieces from Ellington's incidental music to the Stratford, Ontario *Timon of Athens* and, above all, the rarely heard *Tone Parallel to Harlem*, a long suite which is, by common agreement, Ellington's most ambitious and successful composition.

Possibly the old master has extended his admirers—an unvaguish assembly with a high proportion of spectacles and adults and a low quota of beards and girls—a little too far. 'It's more like an LP,' was one opinion overheard in the foyer, and the applause was sometimes dutiful rather than mad. Yet the professional musicians, students and young technicians, the now middle-aged accountants, salesmen, doctors and teachers, who make up the hard core of the Duke's British public, are used to getting a sense of solid satisfaction rather than bacchantic revelry from him—few of them, alas, have heard him on his home ground, a night-club stand—and that certainly is what they all felt. They are wrong. Nothing but wild enthusiasm will do for what Ellington gave us.

His present band, except for the reeds, is not without weaknesses on the solo side. There is no trombone voice to balance the sentimental Lawrence Brown, nor the sort of trumpet note which Shorty Baker provided so well. Cootie Williams, back in the band after many years, brings to it an intense, introverted, primitive blues-cry, an echo of golden-age Armstrong, but what he now plays seems specialised and technically undemanding. Rolf Ericson, a Swede, plays brisk but colourless flugelhorn. Yet the quality of the music and the novelty, which keeps the players on their mettle, more than offset these weaknesses. The Duke, plainly, is in one of his creative periods and the band knows it.

Ellington's strength and weakness is that he is essentially a pop composer. He thinks in images and memories. The word Harlem suggests the first theme of his suite, the bass 'walks' us through our conducted tour of the place, pretty girls turn into pretty tunes. His Far East has much of the Orient of cabarets called Soraya and cinema mood music. He brings to this pop world the astringency—as well as the sentimentality—

of the man-about-town, a marvellous cool and skipping wit, and the entire tradition of black music: what is elsewhere mere archaeological excavation, the down-home blues, the creole clarinet of New Orleans, the stride piano of the Twenties, is the living matter of music in the Ellington band of 1964. He brings to it his peculiar genius for orchestral writing. How many composers, live or dead, can get the precise—and planned—effect of the passage in the Harlem suite in which the bass alternates first with Hamilton's liquid clarinet, then with Procope's huskier one, backed by Gonsalves, until the strong entry of the trombones precisely pointed up with the trumpets? Pop-based music does not fly high; emotionally—except where the fate of Ellington's people is at stake—it has its limitations, which come out in the Shakespeare scores. But his pop roots do not prevent him from writing serious music—perhaps the most serious being written in the U.S. Duke Ellington is a great man, a unique figure in the history of modern music. His orchestra will eventually die with him, and records alone will preserve his irreproducible works. Can we afford not to listen to him when he does us the honour to treat us as an audience worthy of him?

New Thing

The penalty of 'art' in our time is that it is supposed to progress, and consequently to develop an avant-garde. The penalty of salesmanship in our time is fashion-change. Since jazz has, for better or worse, come to consider itself an art, and since it has always had to sell itself on the market, it has developed both a belief in the importance of progress, and of an avant-garde, and a cycle of fashion-change. You have got, as they say, to pay your dues.

Jazz began to suffer the consequences of this adjustment to modern culture about the time of the Second World War. Before then its low social status had preserved its independence. There was no special prestige in being a jazz musician, for even within the black ghetto it was not a respectable, though it could be a very prosperous, occupation. The jazz musician was an entertainer, and if his private inspiration did not coincide with the taste of the public or the bookers, he would not be an

artist, but merely a janitor or postman. The most eminent of older black musicians still preserve the pattern of behaviour of this professionalism, though sometimes with a considerable admixture of irony. Duke Ellington knows, and knows that by now most of his public knows, that he is a great deal more than a sort of glorified musical valet of the leisure-classes, as in the Cotton Club days, but his public comportment is still that of a Jeeves who humours a public of Bertie Woosters.

Again, though jazz undoubtedly evolved—and much faster than any other kind of music in the twentieth century—it is extremely dangerous to think of its changes as analogous to those of the orthodox arts. Its framework was that of working craftsmen, their object to start with perfection and not novelty as such. For a great many of the older artists, perfection came with personal maturity. Once they had developed ‘their’ style, they might vary and deepen it, but they hardly thought of changing it, and when they were tempted to do so (as the great Coleman Hawkins was at one time by Bebop), the results were not usually encouraging. That is why the jazz of 1935–40, when the music first reached a satisfactory stage of technical maturity, is still practised by virtually all the musicians who had made their reputations by that period. The lessons and novelties of the later period have been absorbed, but have not been allowed to swamp the basic ‘classical’ styles: Ellington is once again the great example. Fortunately, they may be heard to this day—from the saxophone of Ben Webster, now on a welcome return visit to this country, from the trumpet of Buck Clayton or the trombone of Vic Dickenson, who have also come back to us, and of course from the mouths of the simpler and older blues-singers like the indestructible Joe Turner. For out of the Kansas City of the 1930s, with which all these excellent visitors are associated, came the most lasting formula for orchestral jazz so far evolved. None of these artists has any bias against more modern developments in jazz, but none of them has the slightest feeling that somehow they ought to have kept up.

The jazz revolution of the early 1940s changed all that, though not quite as radically as it seemed in the great days of Minton’s. Dizzy Gillespie himself has quietly returned from the furthest outposts of the avant-garde to a renovated version of classic Swing; but then Gillespie, a remarkably intelligent, ironic and well-balanced artist without the

slightest tendency to self-destruction, has always had more in common with the older professional virtuosos than the Charlie Parker Rimbaudians who set the pace for the new movement. Still, from the early 1940s there was for the first time in jazz an avant-garde which cherished its musical revolutionism as such, saw itself as doing the peasantry a favour.

The novelty of the Boppers lay not in the mere fact of experiment. It lay (to quote Sidney Finkelstein) in working out a conscious, sometimes rigid system from the new elements, which in turn reflected a new generation of jazz-players' claim to special status as revolutionary artists. Before Parker, men played jazz, sometimes in older, sometimes in newer ways. After Parker, some of them played 'modern jazz' until new generations of rebels made *them* old-fashioned.

The curious thing is that it took 20 years for this to happen, though not for want of trying. None of the jazz experiments of the late 1940s and 50s produced an accepted corpus of ultra-revolutionism. The most successful of them produced self-contained adaptations of the 'modern' idiom, such as Miles Davis's or the Modern Jazz Quartet's, but not—with the possible brief exception of the 'cool jazz' of the early 1950s—schools. The more deliberately 'progressive' fell flat, though there is now a renewed interest in people like Lennie Tristano as precursors of the 'new thing' of the 1960s. Neither did the attempts to fuse jazz with modern orthodox music ('third stream') start any general stampede in the direction of the symphony orchestra. By the end of the 1950s modern jazz appeared to have settled down, after its exploratory youth, into its own form of traditionalism—hard-swinging, blues-and gospel-influenced neo-Bopping. What passed for novelty was often the rediscovery of long-underrated artists like Thelonious Monk.

Since 1960 a new official avant-garde has appeared. At all events it now has a label, the rather despairing one of 'the new thing', a number of young players in New York following in the steps of the masters (Ornette Coleman, Cecil Taylor, the late Eric Dolphy), a number of sceptics among both musicians and critics, and some non-playing champions like the militant black writer LeRoi Jones, whose book on the blues has attracted deserved praise. As usual, everybody finds it a lot easier to say what the rebellion is against than what it is for. 'It sets aside tonality, the

unwavering beat, the conventional chord structure, and improvisation that is chiefly based on chord progressions.’ Such definitions are no more helpful than the sibylline statements which jazz avant-gardists have now taken over from the avant-garde painters who used to have a quasi-monopoly of such nonsense, such as: ‘For musicians only: time is not speed; it’s distance, and sound is measured motion.’ If ‘the new thing’ lasts, we shall no doubt retrospectively discover the rules of the game, since without rules there is no game. ‘Freedom’ is not a programme, but simply a declaration of the intent to secede.

Meanwhile those of us who do not claim to understand ‘the new thing’—including this critic—can merely grasp at two fairly substantial straws. The first is the fact that there *is* a new movement in New York, though very little of it is heard over here except on a few Blue Note or EMI records, and not much is heard in Manhattan because the public does not want to pay for it. We are now clearly past the point when anything that sounded vaguely unfamiliar, like the gimmicky multi-instrumentalism of Roland Kirk, was hailed as a step forward, since the exhaustion of the 1940s idiom was evident.

The second, and more substantial, is the sheer quality of some of the new musicians, such as Ornette Coleman and the more intellectual Cecil Taylor. There is in the best of the new music a ferocious passion (in Coleman often recognisably based on the blues of his native habitat), just as in the worst there is lots of excessively long, loud and undisciplined doodling. There is at its best an ability to find genuinely original and suitable noises for a recognisable human predicament: so much so that ‘the new thing’ has been called (wrongly) a music of social protest—a musical equivalent, maybe, of Harlem Maoism.

On the other hand, one must make two obvious reservations. The first is that the present ‘school’ will not necessarily turn out to be the main vehicle for the new departure in jazz. Some of its stars may have neither the technical nor the emotional staying-power to hold a movement together: neither Ornette Coleman nor Sonny Rollins, for instance, have returned audibly better than before from their self-imposed retreats into silence and rethinking. Some of the more widely publicised ‘new thingers’, like the saxophonist Archie Shepp, have yet to prove themselves. (Still, it is a promising sign that there are new saxes, for the

history of modern jazz can almost be written in terms of a succession of boss reed-players.) Older innovators, who somehow just missed being elevated into *chefs d'école*, like Mingus or Bill Evans, may retrospectively turn out to be equally important.

Finally, 'the new thing' won't determine the future of jazz until the ordinary non-avant-garde players absorb its innovations. Unlike the painting avant-garde, which rests on the prices fetched by individual works, and on patronage, the jazz avant-garde cannot yet be parlayed into prosperity by a few dealers and critics. It has to sell records, and it has to attract a paying public, and so far it is doing neither. Above all, it has to be played by the craftsmen, the way 'modern' jazz was played by the frustrated musicians in rock-and-roll bands. Perhaps it will be, perhaps not. But it does look as though, for the first time since Parker, a fresh phase has begun.